the Solomon Islands was a combined offensive involving the army and the navy, and lasted for several months. Both were crushing defeats for the Japanese.

After this, the American forces were able to re-take the Philippines. Gradually the Japanese were thrown out of most of their conquered territories. In 1944, the combined British and Indian armies were able to push back the Japanese who attempted to invade the north-east of India. Then, along with the Chinese, they pushed the Japanese out of Burma, and liberated Malaya and Singapore.

Hiroshima and Nagasaki,August 1945

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As a top secret project, using the latest scientific advances, the US developed an atomic bomb immensely more powerful than conventional explosives. The Japanese generals refused to surrender and finally the US dropped an atomic bomb on Hiroshima. As the Japanese still refused to surrender, another atom bomb was dropped on Nagasaki. Japan ultimately announced surrender on 15 August 1945 and formally signed 2 September 1945 bringing an end to World War II.



(c) Effects of the War

New geo-political power alignment: World War II changed the world in fundamental ways. The world was polarized into two main blocs led by superpowers, one led by the United States with a pronounced anti-Communist ideology, and the other by Soviet Russia. Europe was divided into two: Communist and non-Communist.

Nuclear proliferation: The United States and the Soviet Union entered into a race to have more nuclear powered weapons. They built a large stockpile of such weapons. Defence spending sky-rocketed in many countries.

International agencies: Many international agencies, in particular the United Nations, the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund came into existence providing a forum for countries large and small.

Colonial powers were forced to give independence to former colonies in a process of decolonization. India was the first to achieve independence.

3.2 Holocaust and Its Fallout

After Hitler came to power, the Jews were persecuted in many ways. They were deprived of their civil rights, their properties were confiscated and many were confined to ghettos. Eventually, the Nazis came up with the notion of the Final Solution, which was to exterminate the Jews completely.

The word 'holocaust' is used to describe the genocide of nearly six million Jews by the Germans during World War II. Annihilating the Jews was one of the main items on the political agenda of Hitler and the Nazis. Hitler was able to play on the anti-Jewish feelings (anti-Semitism) which were common in Germany and, in fact, throughout Europe. Jews were scattered all across Europe and many had become prominent in business, in performing arts and professional fields. Money-lending was a major business activity among Jews and this strengthened the prejudice against them. Shakespeare's play, *The Merchant of Venice* clearly depicts the dislike and distrust of Jews among the people.

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